Brücke

Getting started: a complete beginner's guide

From installing Python to your first German lesson. No programming experience needed.

MAC EDITION

Who this guide is for

Anyone who wants to use **Brücke**, a personal German and French trainer that takes you from beginner (A1) to intermediate (B1) in 26 weeks, and has **never written code or used a command line**. Every step says exactly what to click and what to type, and shows what you should see afterwards.

What you need

- A **MacBook** or other Mac with a recent macOS, and its login password. On Windows? Use the **Windows edition**.
- An **internet connection** for the one-time setup. After that, Brücke works offline.
- **Google Chrome** (free from google.com/chrome) or **Microsoft Edge**, for the best voices and speech recognition.
- About **30 minutes**. You only do the setup once.

What's inside

Part 1	**Setting up** (once)	Steps 1–6: install Python, download Brücke, start it
Part 2	**Every day**	Starting and stopping Brücke, plus a double-click starter
Part 3	**Using Brücke**	A tour of the screens, the colour code and the shortcuts
Part 4	**Extras and help**	AI writing feedback, backups, updates, fixing problems

BEFORE YOU START

A few words you'll meet

You don't need to understand how any of this works inside. These are the only terms the guide uses:

Word	What it means here
Python	A free program that runs other programs. Brücke is written in Python, so your Mac needs it first.
Terminal	An app that comes with every Mac. It's a window where you *type* instructions instead of clicking. It looks plain and old-fashioned. That's normal.
Command	One line of text you type into Terminal, then press **Return** to run it.
Finder	The Mac app for browsing your files and folders: the smiling blue face in the Dock.
Toolbox (virtual environment)	A private folder called **.venv** that holds Python and Brücke's packages, kept separate from everything else on your Mac.
localhost	"This computer." Brücke runs on your own Mac and you open it in your browser like a website, but nothing goes online.

Two keys that look alike

Key	Symbol	Used in this guide for
Command	⌘	Opening apps (⌘ + Space), quitting (⌘ + Q), pasting (⌘ + V)
Control	^	**Stopping Brücke** (^ + C). Note that it's Control here, *not* Command.

How to read the boxes in this guide

TYPE THIS, THEN PRESS RETURN

```
python3 --version
```

A dark box like the one above is a **command**. Type it into Terminal **exactly** as shown, with the same capital letters, spaces, dots and slashes, then press **Return**.

WHAT YOU SHOULD SEE

```
Python 3.15.1
```

A grey box like this one shows what Terminal should print back. Your numbers may differ slightly.
Copy and paste works: copy a command from this PDF, paste it into Terminal with ⌘ + V, then press Return.

PART 1 · SETTING UP (ONCE)

Six steps to your first lesson

Do these in order. Each one only takes a few minutes, and you will never have to repeat most of them.

1 Install Python

Free, from the official website. About 5 minutes.

1. Open your browser and go to **python.org/downloads**.
2. Click the big yellow **Download Python** button. The site recognises your Mac and gives you the macOS installer.
3. Open the downloaded file (click **Downloads** in the Dock or in Finder). Click **Continue** through the screens, **Agree** to the licence, then **Install**. Type your Mac's login password when asked.
4. When it finishes, a Finder window opens showing a Python folder. **Double-click "Install Certificates.command"**. This lets Python make secure internet connections. A Terminal window flashes some text, then you can close it.

Now check that it worked. Open **Terminal**: press ⌘ + **Space**, type **terminal**, and press Return. A plain window opens. Type:

TYPE THIS, THEN PRESS RETURN

```
python3 --version
```

WHAT YOU SHOULD SEE

```
Python 3.15.1
```

A pop-up offers to install "command line developer tools"?

Click **Cancel**. That's Apple's own offer, and it appears when the Python from python.org isn't found yet. Make sure you finished the installer above, then quit Terminal (⌘ + **Q**), open it again, and run **python3 --version** once more.

Always python3 on a Mac

On a Mac, the command is **python3** with a 3, not python. Typing plain python usually just gives "command not found".

2 Download Brücke

From GitHub, a website where programmers share code. No account needed.

1. Go to **github.com/oladapo-joseph/brucke**.
2. Click the green **<> Code** button, then **Download ZIP** at the bottom of the menu that opens.
3. Open your **Downloads** folder in Finder. Safari usually unzips the download for you, so you'll see a **brucke-main** folder. If you see **brucke-main.zip** instead, double-click it to unzip it.
4. Drag the **brucke-main** folder onto **Documents** in Finder's sidebar. You can rename it to **Brucke** if you like. Do this now, *before* Step 4.

Open the folder. You are in the right place when you can see these items:

Inside the Brücke folder	
app · **static** · **docs** · **tests**	folders
requirements.txt · **README.md** · **run.sh**	files

3 Point Terminal at the Brücke folder

So the commands you type act on Brücke's files.

1. In Terminal, type **cd** followed by **one space**. Don't press Return yet.
2. In Finder, **drag the Brücke folder** and drop it onto the Terminal window. Its full location appears after the cd.
3. Now press **Return**.

IT WILL LOOK SOMETHING LIKE THIS (WITH YOUR NAME)

```
cd /Users/ada/Documents/brucke-main
```

To check you're in the right place, type **ls** (short for "list") and press Return:

TYPE THIS, THEN PRESS RETURN

```
ls
```

WHAT YOU SHOULD SEE

```
README.md       app       docs       requirements.txt
run.sh          static    tests
```

> **If macOS asks about your Documents folder**
>
> A message like **"Terminal would like to access files in your Documents folder"** may appear. Click **Allow**.

4 Create Brücke's private toolbox

One command. It makes a folder called .venv.

This gives Brücke its own private copy of Python to install packages into, so nothing else on your Mac is affected. In the same Terminal window, type:

TYPE THIS, THEN PRESS RETURN

```
python3 -m venv .venv
```

Nothing seems to happen for a few seconds, then the prompt comes back without any message. That means it worked.

> **Where did it go?**
>
> Finder hides names that start with a dot, so you won't see **.venv** in the folder. That's fine. To show or hide hidden items in Finder, press ⌘ + ⇧ + **.** (Command, Shift and the full-stop key).

5 Install Brücke's packages

Downloads the building blocks Brücke needs. 1 to 3 minutes.

Still in the same window, type this (carefully: it starts with a dot and uses forward slashes):

TYPE THIS, THEN PRESS RETURN

```
.venv/bin/python -m pip install -r requirements.txt
```

Lots of text scrolls past while packages download. Wait until the prompt returns. The last lines should look like:

WHAT YOU SHOULD SEE

```
Successfully installed anthropic-... fastapi-... uvicorn-... (and others)
```

> **Why the long ".venv/bin/python" at the start?**
>
> It tells your Mac to use the Python **inside Brücke's toolbox**, the one that has the packages. If you type plain **python3** or **uvicorn** later, your Mac uses a Python that has none of them, and you get the error **No module named 'fastapi'**. So always type the commands exactly as written here.

6 Start Brücke and open it

The moment of truth.

TYPE THIS, THEN PRESS RETURN

```
.venv/bin/python -m uvicorn app.main:app
```

WHAT YOU SHOULD SEE

```
INFO:     Started server process [12345]
INFO:     Waiting for application startup.
INFO:     Application startup complete.
INFO:     Uvicorn running on http://127.0.0.1:8000 (Press CTRL+C to quit)
```

Brücke is now running. Open **Chrome** or **Edge** and type this into the address bar:

TYPE THIS INTO YOUR BROWSER'S ADDRESS BAR

```
http://localhost:8000
```

You should see Brücke's **Today** page. You're done with setup. Bookmark the page so it's one click next time.

> **Keep the Terminal window open**
>
> That window *is* Brücke running. If you close it, the page stops working. You can minimise it (yellow button, or ⌘ + **M**), but don't close it while you're studying.

PART 2 · EVERY DAY

Starting and stopping Brücke

From now on you never repeat Steps 1, 2, 4 or 5. Each study session is just:

	To start studying	
1	Open Terminal (⌘ + Space, type **terminal**), type **cd** and a space, drag in the Brücke folder, press Return	(Step 3)
2	Type `.venv/bin/python -m uvicorn app.main:app` and press Return	(Step 6)
3	Open **http://localhost:8000** in Chrome or Edge (or click your bookmark)	

To stop, click inside the Terminal window and press **Control + C** (^ C, *not* ⌘ C). Your progress is saved automatically after every answer, so there's no "save" button to worry about.

> **Pressing the up-arrow key saves typing**
>
> Terminal remembers commands you typed before. Press ↑ to step back through them, and press Return when the one you want appears. That includes the cd command from last time.

Optional: a double-click starter

If you'd rather not type anything at all, let Terminal create a small starter file for you. With Terminal in the Brücke folder (Step 3), paste in all five lines at once and press Return:

PASTE ALL FIVE LINES, THEN PRESS RETURN

```
echo '#!/bin/bash' > "Start Brucke.command"
echo 'cd "$(dirname "$0")"' >> "Start Brucke.command"
echo '(sleep 2; open http://localhost:8000) &' >> "Start Brucke.command"
echo '.venv/bin/python -m uvicorn app.main:app' >> "Start Brucke.command"
chmod +x "Start Brucke.command"
```

A file called **Start Brucke** appears in the Brücke folder. **Double-click it**: a Terminal window opens (that's Brücke running, so leave it open) and two seconds later your browser opens Brücke. For one-click access, drag the file into the **right-hand end of the Dock**, next to the Bin.

> **If macOS won't open it**
>
> If a message says the file can't be opened, **right-click** (or Control-click) it, choose **Open**, then click **Open** again. You only need to do this once.

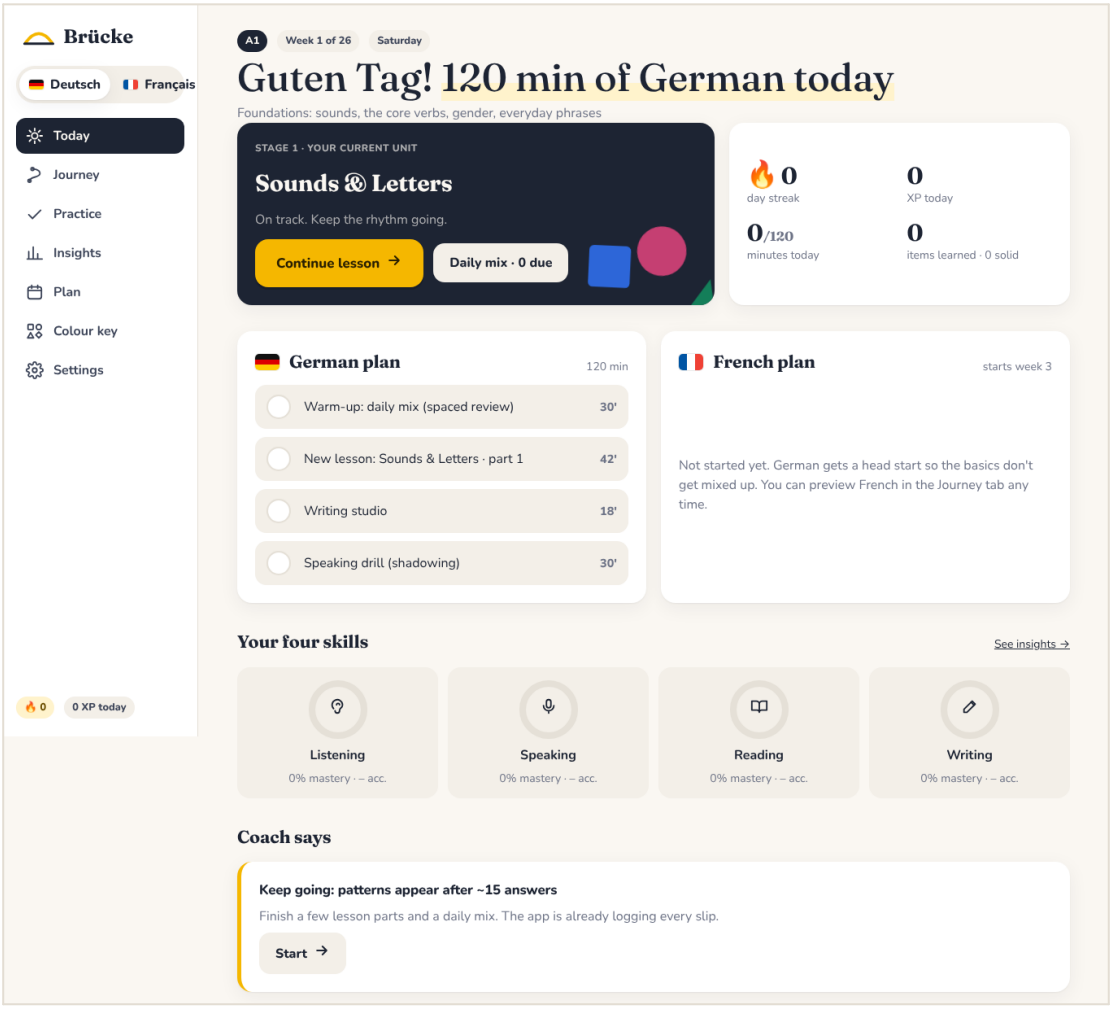
> **When you close a Brücke Terminal window**
>
> Terminal may ask **"Do you want to terminate running processes in this window?"**. Clicking **Terminate** stops Brücke, which is what you want when you've finished studying.

A tour of the app

Brücke (German for *bridge*) uses English as the bridge to German and French. German starts in week 1 and French joins in week 3. The menu on the left takes you to every screen. Switch language with the **Deutsch / Français** buttons at the top of the menu.

Today: your daily plan

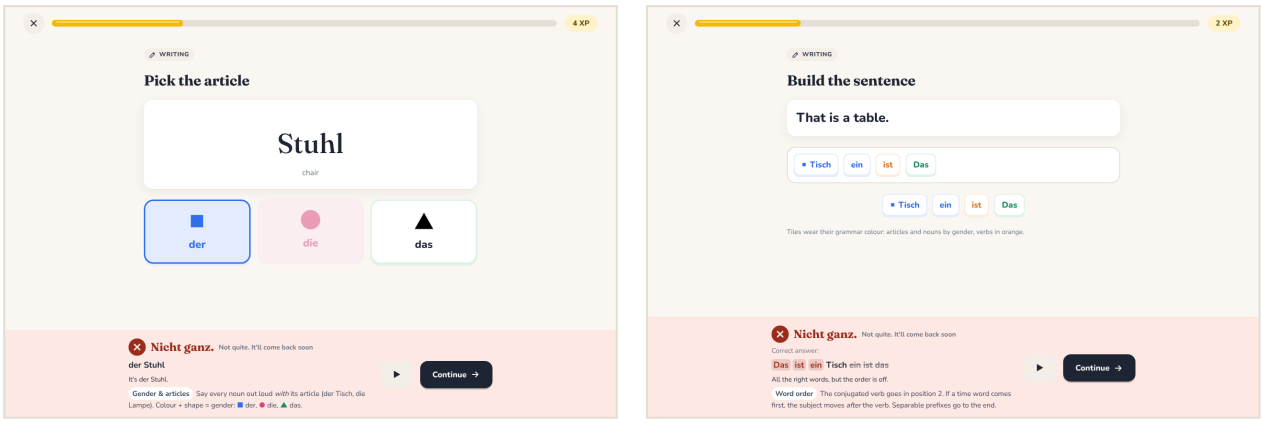
This is where every session begins. Press **Continue lesson** for new material, or **Daily mix** to review words that are due. The plan below lists today's blocks in order. Underneath you'll see how strong each of your four skills is (listening, speaking, reading, writing) and a tip from the coach.



The Today page on day one.

Answering exercises

Exercises mix all four skills: picking an article, building a sentence from tiles, typing what you hear, repeating a phrase out loud. After each answer a panel slides up. Green means correct. Red (*Nicht ganz*, "not quite") shows the right answer, explains **what kind of mistake** it was, and lets you replay the audio. Press **Continue** or **Return** to move on. Anything you miss comes back again soon.



Left: pick the article. Right: build the sentence. Both show the feedback panel after a mistake.

The colour and shape code

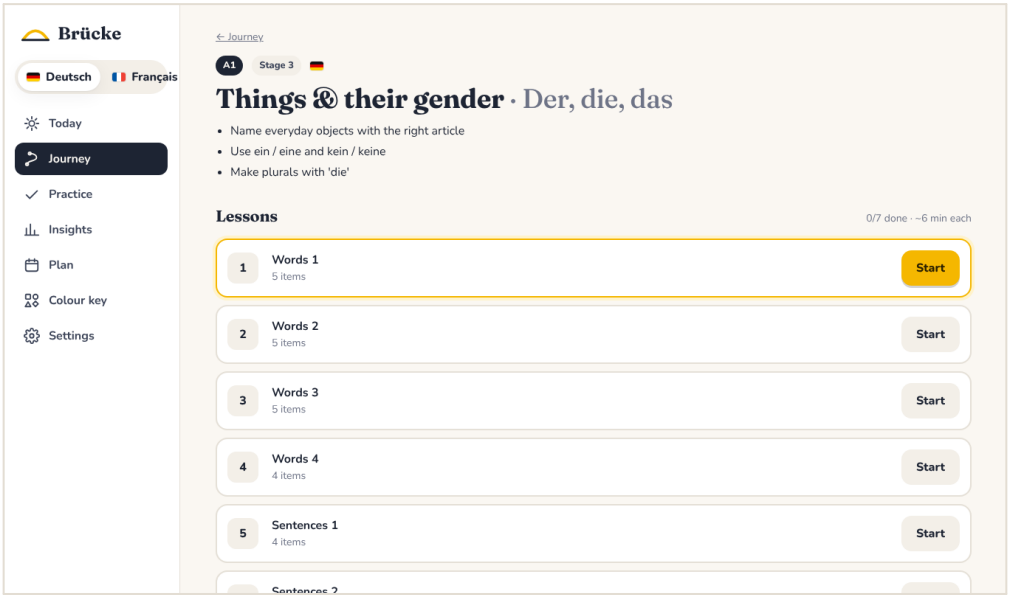
Brücke paints grammar the same way everywhere: in word lists, sentences, tiles and buttons. The shapes mean it still works if you're colour-blind. Learn these five and you'll see a word's gender at a glance:

	Means	German	French
■	**Blue square** · masculine	der Tisch	le livre
●	**Rose circle** · feminine	die Lampe	la table
▲	**Green triangle** · neuter	das Buch	(French has no neuter)
◆	**Violet diamond** · plural	die Bücher	les livres
→	**Orange arrow** · verbs	ist, haben	est, avoir

Open **Colour key** in the menu any time to see it again.

Journey: the whole course

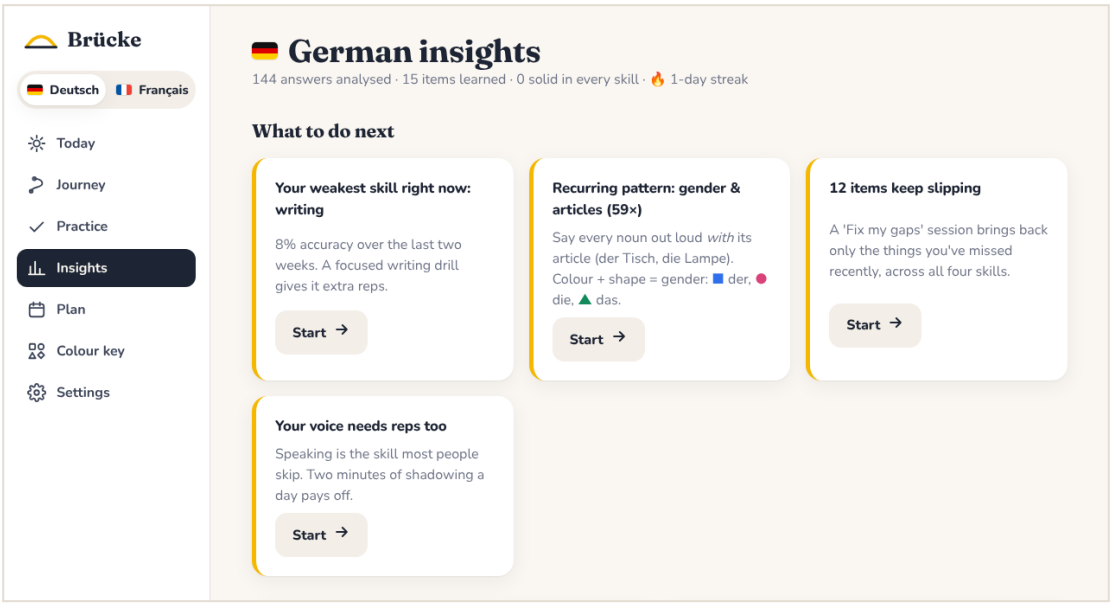
Journey shows all the stages. Open one to see its lessons (about 6 minutes each), short grammar explanations, the word list (click any word to hear it) and example sentences. Already know a topic? Use **"I know this"** to test out: score 85% or more and it's marked as done.



A unit in Journey: lessons, grammar ideas, then the words below.

Practice, Insights and Plan

- **Practice**: extra sessions on demand. It focuses on what's due for review, your weakest skill, and the mistakes you keep making.
- **Insights**: what you're good at and what keeps tripping you up, with a **Start** button next to each suggestion and a **Fix these** button for the words you keep missing. Patterns start appearing after about 15 answers.
- **Plan**: your 26-week timeline, the weekly rhythm (Sundays are for review) and checkpoint tests in weeks 4, 8, 13, 17, 22 and 26.



Insights turns your mistakes into suggestions.



Plan: German starts in week 1, French in week 3.

Settings

Change your **start date**, **minutes per day**, **which language comes first** and **when the second one starts**. Brücke adjusts difficulty automatically (levels 1–5). You can fix a level here if you prefer, or unlock the stretch stages towards B2 early.

Speaking and listening

- The first time an exercise needs your microphone, two permission requests may appear: one from **macOS** ("Google Chrome would like to access the microphone") and one from the **browser**. Click **OK** / **Allow** on both.
- You'll hear a phrase at normal and slow speed, then say it. Brücke scores you word by word and highlights the words it couldn't make out.
- No sound? Check your volume and that you're using Chrome or Edge, which have the most natural voices.

Keyboard shortcuts

Key	What it does
Return	Check your answer / continue
1 – 4	Pick answer 1, 2, 3 or 4
Space	Replay the audio, or start the microphone
Esc	Leave the exercise
⌘ + Return	Submit your writing in the Writing studio

PART 4 · EXTRAS AND HELP

Optional: AI writing feedback

Everything in Brücke works without this. If you add an **Anthropic API key**, two extra features switch on: the **Writing studio** corrects your free writing with a score, a level estimate and explanations, and Brücke can **generate the full lessons** for the later stages (9–26), which otherwise exist only as outlines.

> **This costs money**
>
> An API key is billed by usage by Anthropic, the company behind Claude, separately from any Claude subscription. Treat the key like a password: never share it, and never send someone your Brücke folder while the key is in it.

1. Create an account at **console.anthropic.com**, add credit under **Billing**, then go to **API keys** → **Create key**. Copy the key. It starts with **sk-ant-**.
2. With Brücke stopped and Terminal in the Brücke folder (Step 3), type this line. Replace **sk-ant-paste-your-key-here** with your own key, and keep the single quotes:

TYPE THIS, THEN PRESS RETURN

```
echo 'ANTHROPIC_API_KEY=sk-ant-paste-your-key-here' > .env
```

3. Start Brücke again (Step 6). It only reads the key when it starts.

> **Why Terminal and not TextEdit?**
>
> The file must be called exactly **.env**. Finder won't let you create names that start with a dot, and TextEdit adds formatting and a .txt or .rtf ending, so Terminal is the easy way. To check it, type **cat .env** and you should see your line printed back.

Keep your progress safe

All your progress lives in a single file: **bruecke.db** in the **data** folder inside the Brücke folder. It appears after your first session. To back it up, stop Brücke and then copy that file to a USB stick or iCloud Drive. To restore it, put the copy back in the same place.

Getting a newer version

1. Stop Brücke. Download and unzip the new version exactly as in Step 2, into a **new** folder.
2. Copy the **data** folder from your old Brücke folder into the new one, so your progress comes with you. If you set up AI feedback, press ⌘ + ⇧ + **.** in Finder to show hidden files and copy **.env** across too.
3. Point Terminal at the new folder and repeat **Steps 4, 5 and 6**. When everything works, you can drag the old folder to the Bin.

When something goes wrong

Find the message you're seeing in the left column. Error text in Terminal looks alarming, but it's usually one of these.

What you see	What it means	What to do
zsh: command not found: python3, or a pop-up offering **command line developer tools**	Python from python.org isn't installed or found yet.	Click Cancel on the pop-up. Do Step 1, then quit Terminal (⌘ + Q) and open it again.
ModuleNotFoundError: No module named 'fastapi' (or 'uvicorn')	A Python *without* Brücke's packages was used.	Start Brücke with the full command: `.venv/bin/python -m uvicorn app.main:app`. Don't shorten it. Still failing? Repeat Step 5.
Could not open requirements file, or **Could not import module "app.main"**	Terminal isn't pointed at the Brücke folder.	Redo Step 3, then type **ls** and check you can see **requirements.txt**.
no such file or directory: .venv/bin/python	Wrong folder, or no toolbox yet.	Check the folder (Step 3), then do Steps 4 and 5.
[Errno 48] Address already in use	Brücke is already running in another Terminal window.	Use the page that's already open, or press ^ + C in the other window.
SSL: CERTIFICATE_VERIFY_FAILED	Python can't check secure websites yet.	Open **Applications** → **Python 3.x** in Finder, double-click **Install Certificates.command**, then try again.
Browser says **This site can't be reached**	Brücke isn't running.	Start it (Step 6) and keep its window open. Check the address is **http://localhost:8000**.
Microphone exercises don't hear you	macOS or the browser is blocking the mic.	**System Settings** → **Privacy & Security** → **Microphone**: turn on Chrome. Then allow the mic in the browser.
Start Brucke opens in a text editor, or says **permission denied**	The starter isn't marked as a program.	In Terminal, in the Brücke folder, run `chmod +x "Start Brucke.command"`.
Writing studio says AI feedback isn't available	No API key was found.	Type **cat .env** in the Brücke folder. No key shown? Redo the .env step, then restart Brücke.
Things broke after you **moved or renamed** the Brücke folder	The toolbox (.venv) remembers its old location.	Press ⌘ + ⇧ + . in Finder to show hidden items, drag **.venv** to the Bin, then repeat Steps 4 and 5. Your progress is safe.
Lots of error text during Step 5	Usually a dropped internet connection.	Run the same command again. If it keeps failing, copy the last ten lines and send them to whoever shared Brücke with you.

CHEAT SHEET

Everything on one page

When	Type this in Terminal
Go to the Brücke folder	`cd` (with a space), drag the folder in, press Return
Check you're in the right place	`ls`
Check Python is installed	`python3 --version`
Create the toolbox (once)	`python3 -m venv .venv`
Install packages (once)	`.venv/bin/python -m pip install -r requirements.txt`
Start Brücke (every time)	`.venv/bin/python -m uvicorn app.main:app`
Open it	**http://localhost:8000** in Chrome or Edge
Stop it	**Control + C** (^ C) in the Terminal window

Handy Mac shortcuts	
⌘ + **Space**	Open Spotlight to find an app such as Terminal
⌘ + **V**	Paste
⌘ + **Q**	Quit the app you're in
⌘ + ⇧ + **.**	Show or hide hidden files in Finder
↑ in Terminal	Bring back a command you typed earlier

Viel Erfolg! · Bonne chance !

Good luck. A little every day beats a lot once a week.